



BEFORE

The armies confronting one another in Virginia at the start of 1862 were both commanded by generals who were regarded as too negative-minded by their presidents.

SOUTHERN ANTAGONISM

In March 1862, Confederate general Joseph **E. Johnston** withdrew his army from **Bull Run**. This retreat, together with the destruction of many supplies, was initially carried out **without informing President Davis**. Johnston's obstinacy angered Davis, and on March 13, **General Lee assumed the role as his military adviser**.

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The number of pages in a letter sent by General McClellan to President Lincoln, rejecting the president's proposal for an overland offensive against Richmond in 1862.

McCLELLAN'S DETERMINATION

Lincoln repeatedly urged an **offensive to break through** the Confederate line between Washington and Richmond. General **George B. McClellan**, commanding the Army of the Potomac, instituted his own plan to **outflank the Confederate defenses** and take Richmond.

The Virginia Peninsula is a tongue of land stretching east from Richmond, between the York River to the north and the James River to the south. Eager to exploit Union command of the sea, General McClellan originally planned to transport his troops from Washington along the Potomac River into Chesapeake Bay for a landing at Urbanna on the Rappahannock River. Having bypassed the Confederate army at Manassas, south of Washington, he would then have a relatively clear run at the Confederate capital. Yet Southern General Joseph Johnston's retreat south of the Rappahannock in March 1862 forestalled him. Instead, the Union Army of the Potomac landed at Fort Monroe on the tip of the Virginia Peninsula. By April 4, McClellan had almost 60,000 troops with which to begin an advance up the Peninsula to Richmond, and thousands more were arriving. In front was a Confederate line on the Warwick River at Yorktown, lightly manned by 14,000 troops. In Washington, Lincoln, afraid that McClellan's move had left the capital exposed to a surprise attack, urged the general to make haste with an immediate assault on the Warwick River defenses, but McClellan dismissed this as military naïveté. Johnston later commented: "No one but McClellan would have hesitated to attack."